



GREY BANNER ALERT



SHW Serious Incident (SI) – Final Notice

Date of Incident	7 th April 2026	Time of Incident	12:00 PM
Directorate / Region	RMO – Kimberley	Main Roads or Contractor	Main Roads
EQSafe Event Type	Procedure Breach	EQSafe Incident Number	57801
Actual Consequence	Moderate	Potential Consequence	Major

Incident Short Description	Chain used for recovery of maintenance truck, snaps and recoils smashing guard and windscreen.
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Executive Summary

Maintenance crews were enroute to various sites on Great Northern Highway and had stopped to repair a pothole. As they have pulled over on to the road shoulder, the flocon truck has become bogged. The crew have made multiple attempts to reverse out of the bog, to no avail.

A check of the other truck and light vehicle confirmed that there was no recovery gear available, so the crew have used a 10mm chain which was being used to lash down the posi-track. They've attached the chain to the back of the posi-track and the front of the flocon truck and slowly moved forward to start pulling the flocon out of the bog.

The posi-track was positioned approximately 6 metres from the flocon when the chain has failed under the load, snapping, recoiling and smashing through the mesh windscreen guard and then the windscreen. Fortunately, there was no one on foot at the time (one driver in the flocon, one in the posi-track and another approximately 20 metres away in a light vehicle). Had there been workers on foot, this incident had the potential for serious injury or fatality due to the chain strike.

The crew abandoned the truck recovery and called the incident through to their supervisor. The Supervisor then arranged for a heavy tow to be mobilised.

SHW and the Supervisor then attended to the scene to ensure the safety of the crews and await the tow. It was then confirmed that the flocon truck was on dry hire and this was the first use on hire.

The tow truck arrived at the site at approximately 2:40 PM when recovery commenced. Crew and truck returned to the depot and works were ceased for the day.

Contributing Factors

- There was no recovery equipment available in the heavy vehicle or the light vehicle. The chain used was intended solely for securing (lashing) equipment, not for towing or recovery.
- A risk assessment was also not conducted on the recovery of the vehicle and therefore the risks in using chains for recovery was not recognised – the risks associated with stored energy and recoil during the recovery were not identified or controlled.

- There is no clear recovery procedure for heavy vehicles in the field, meaning there is a gap in the understanding of recovery load dynamics and the risks involved in using incorrect recovery equipment.
- No recovery dampening device, such as a blanket, was used to reduce recoil energy.
- The task evolved from pothole repairs into a complex vehicle recovery.
- There is an underlying perception that job tasks must be completed, which verifies why the crew attempted recovery of the heavy vehicle before communicating the initial bogging incident to the Supervisor.

Corrective Actions

- Develop and implement a Safe Work Instruction for Heavy Vehicle recovery that defines:
 - When a Take 5 or dynamic risk assessment is required, particularly when the task changes from standard operations to vehicle recovery.
 - Stop-work authority reinforcement.
 - Recovery equipment checks, and what to use and when.
- Develop a Heavy Vehicle Recovery practice which covers:
 - Clear guidance on when self-recovery is not permitted, and when it may be attempted.
 - When recovery must cease and when towing can be engaged.
 - Emphasis on lack of recovery equipment requiring immediate escalation.
 - Prohibited use of chains for any vehicle recovery.
- Investigate regional providers who conduct targeted training on heavy vehicle recovery and correct use of recovery gear.
- Update risk registers and SWMS to explicitly address stored energy and recoil risks relating to recovery of any vehicle or plant item.



This serious potential incident aligns with the Main Roads Critical Risk profile relating to
Mobile Plant

Distribution of Notice

Main Roads Personnel and Contracting Organisations